



Comparatives and Superlatives Podcast

Gate 3 – Price comparison

Welcome to Gate 3

You have probably been **lied to** to
about the word equal.

Target Audience: **B1 and C1 English learners.**
Goal: Make perfect price and time comparisons.



The “As... As” Frame

We are taught that “as cheap as” means two things are exactly the same price.

It actually **sets a floor** (meaning at least as cheap).

It tells you absolutely nothing about the **ceiling**.

The Flexible Meaning

Example: "The guest house is **as clean as** the hotel – **cleaner, in fact.**"



If it meant exactly equal, that sentence is a **complete contradiction.**

The listener naturally assumes they are equal,
but you can **break that assumption.**

Keeping Frames Separate

The meaning is flexible, but the **structure is incredibly strict.**



Correct: “**as fast as**”



or “**faster than**”

You must keep those frames **entirely separate.**

Never Mix Them

We can **never mix** the two comparison frames.

✗ Wrong: “**as fast than**”.

✗ Wrong: “**faster as**”.

✗ **faster as**

The “So” Option

If you make the sentence **negative**, you get another option.

You can swap the first “as” for “**so**”.

SO $\equiv$ **AS**

Example: “The airport is **not so crowded as** it used to be.”

Handling Ratios Safely

Words like **twice**, **half**, or **three times** are a massive trap.

They really only work with that “**as as**” frame.



Correct: “**Twice as expensive as**”.

What Not To Do

Do not combine multipliers with the “-er than” frame.

✗ Wrong: “**twice more expensive than**”.

twice more expensive than

This structure is **completely wrong**.

Ambiguous Ratios

THE QUESTION

"The new tunnel is **three times longer than** the old one."

THE ANALYSIS

Does it mean three times the length, or the old length **plus three times more** (four times as long)?

THE CONCLUSION

Both meanings are possible, so **avoid it entirely.**



Perfect Precision

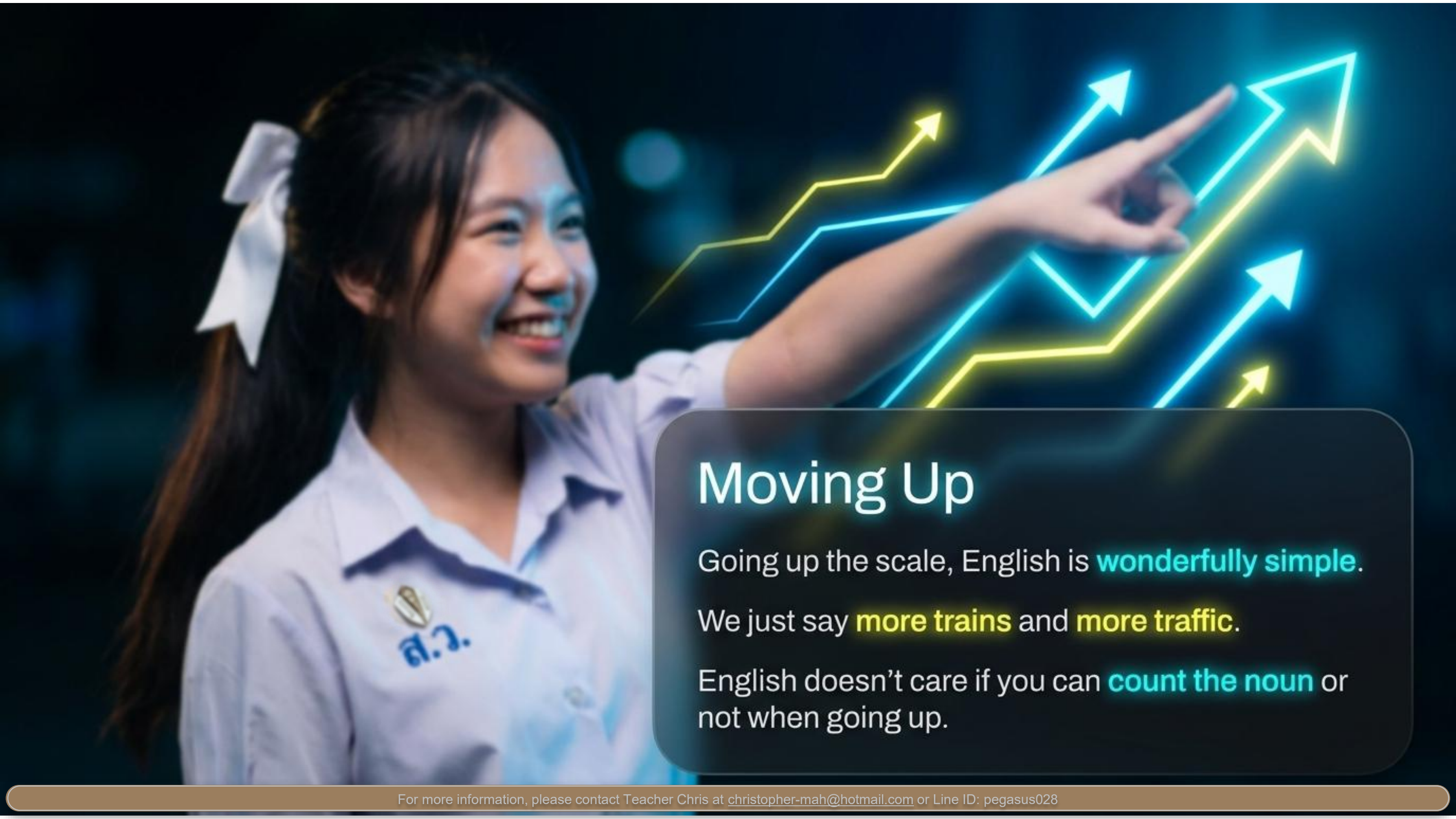
Instead of worrying about adjectives,
just use a **noun phrase**.



Example 1:
"half the journey time of"

Example 2:
"twice the price of"

They leave absolutely **zero room for confusion**.



Moving Up

Going up the scale, English is **wonderfully simple**.

We just say **more trains** and **more traffic**.

English doesn't care if you can **count the noun** or not when going up.

Fewer

The Textbook Rule

Less

Going down is a **completely different story**.

The standard textbook rule says we must divide our words based on whether we can **count the objects**.

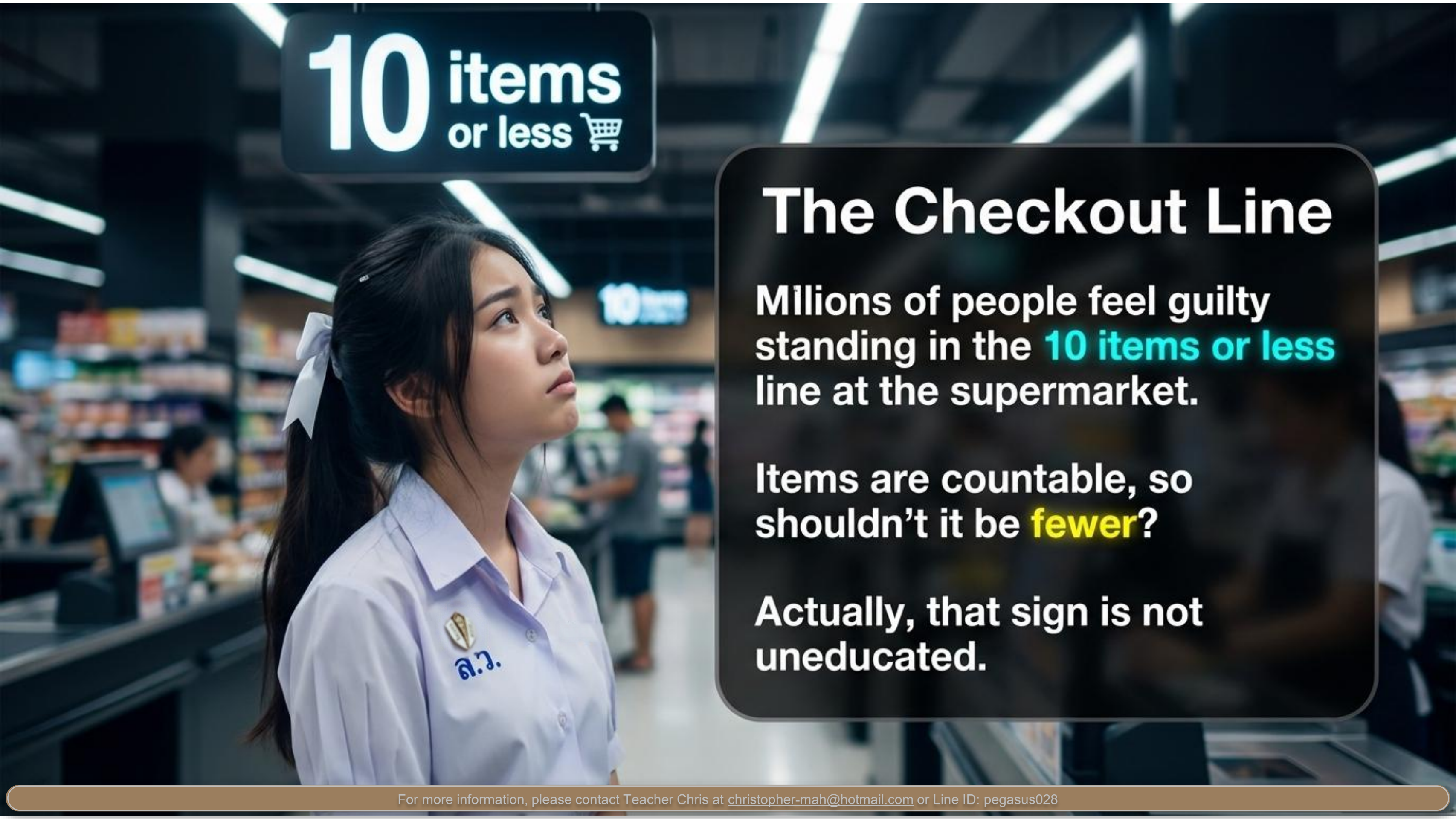




Dividing the Words

We use **fewer** for **countable things** (e.g., **fewer trains**, **fewer passengers**).

We use **less** for **uncountable concepts** (e.g., **less traffic**, **less luggage**).



10 items
or less 🛒

The Checkout Line

Millions of people feel guilty standing in the **10 items or less** line at the supermarket.

Items are countable, so shouldn't it be **fewer**?

Actually, that sign is not uneducated.

A young woman with dark hair tied back with a white bow, wearing a white school uniform shirt with a blue 'ส.ว.' badge, is looking down at a large, unrolled scroll. The scroll contains text in a Gothic script, likely Latin. The background is a blurred library or study with bookshelves.

The Original Standard

Using less with countable things is actually a **thousand years old**.

It was the standard version of English for centuries.

The supermarket sign is using **original English**.

A young woman with dark hair tied back with a white bow, wearing a white school uniform shirt with a blue collar and a blue Thai character 'ส.ว' on the left chest, is sitting in a library. She is holding a large, open, old book with both hands and looking at it with a focused, slightly concerned expression. She is also holding a quill pen in her right hand. The background is a dimly lit library with bookshelves and warm lighting.

The 1770 Preference

A writer named **Robert Baker** came along in 1770. He just decided that fewer **sounded better** to him.

His personal preference was printed and became a **rigid rule for exams**.



Time, Money, and Distance

You still need Baker's rule for exams, but there is a massive exception: **measurements**.

Time, money, and distance always take **less**.

They are singular **total amounts** in your mind, not individual items.

20:00

Total Amounts

Measurements represent total amounts, not individual counts.

Correct: **less than 20 minutes.**

Correct: **less than 5 kilometers.**



Trying to Sound Smart

If you overcorrect to ~~fewer~~ than 20 minutes, you are making a noticeable mistake.

Do not apply the countable rule to measurements.



~~fewer~~

Language Evolution

English is happy using one word **(more)** going up the scale.

If a language only requires a distinction in **one direction**, maybe the textbook rule isn't fundamental.

When you need a ratio, reach for **as as** or a **noun phrase**, never for than!